

Some Myths About Bias: A Queer Studies Reading of Gender Bias in NLP

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Re-framing gender bias via Queer Thoery, this project critiques NLP methods that perpetuate wo persistent "myths" or assumptions about on gender bias:

1. Bias is Categorical (bias is present/absent)
2. Bias is Zero-Sum (equalization = fairness)

These assumptions flatten complex bias types and categories into reductive and ineffective metrics that attempt to “neutralize” or “equalize” bias.

QUEER STUDIES AS A METHODOLOGICAL LENS

Drawing from Queer Theory, this paper argues that "binary thinking":

- Requires exclusions to remain stable (what Judith Butler calls the “necessary outside”).
- Creates hierarchy and asymmetries even when it appears balanced (e.g., heterosexual/homosexual).

Rather than leave the binary behind, however, this project proposes methods that acknowledge and work within the limitations of binary systems, such as:

- Bias amplification techniques (e.g., using “the pretty doctor” to expand representational potential).
- An emphasis on diversity and proliferation of gender expressions in datasets.